

downloads, users, developer contributions and issues reported and pending, as well as the level of engagement, to gauge if the support from the community is strong.

Q How can IT companies ensure active participation from various communities for their open source solutions?

Interaction between the community and company is critical. We need each other. One of the best ways to build community support is to make it easy for contributors and users to collaborate and contribute, and have their voices heard. Companies can communicate the project at meetups and events, and share the many ways people can contribute to, download the software, and be involved.

Also, companies and project leaders need to be responsive to issues and messages in order to create an inclusive community. Having an open and transparent way to collaborate through a good governance model is indeed the key.

Q Where do you see India in terms of open source contributions?

I have not tracked contributions from India closely, but have observed a growing interest and presence from many Indian companies and developers in open source projects that I am a part of.

India has become a great supporter of open source. From students working as interns to developers in multinational and Indian companies, a large part of the country is leveraging open source. The government also has a more open policy regarding the use of open source.

“ A track record of working and contributing to open source is vital when choosing the right talent. ”

Q Do global IT concerns like Western Digital and SanDisk look at hiring developers from India?

Yes, absolutely. The industry needs smart and talented people. We have an office in India, and have many qualified and talented developers that work for us there and even in the US.

Q What qualities do you as an open source head look for in open source developers?

A track record of working and contributing to open source is vital when choosing the right talent. Also, the ability to work with the community and understand the norms of contributing, the variety of licences, the quality of work when involved collaboratively with others in a distributed and remote project—these are some of the key points to consider.

Most important is a passion for doing open source work, which involves a different way of developing. It is important to understand this in order to be effective in a community-run project.

Q Do you think there is a huge gender gap in the tech sphere across the globe?

Yes, unfortunately, there is a gender gap. There are many factors contributing to this. In my opinion, the factors include support at home to learn tech, media images of who is in tech, how school classes are structured, and finally, the culture of the tech world. All of these reinforce some gender stereotypes that tech is male dominated and suited only for men.

However, women nowadays are moving into a new and more visible role, and I encourage that. When I talk to successful women in the tech industry, they have some things in common -- a very supportive home with a parent or spouse who is in tech or encouraged them to get into tech. Early exposure to tech in gaming or other technical areas is also key. A teacher or champion who supported them in engineering school and helped them stay in engineering can also be advantageous. It also takes persistence and strength for a woman to be in tech today. I have done it—and so can other women. Based in Silicon Valley, I see many successful women; so I encourage all of them to take the challenge.

Q How can we build a women-friendly environment in the technology world?

The environment needs to change to include more women and newcomers into tech. There is definitely more awareness today, and things are slowly changing. But some things still need to change.

What we need are mentors and the exposure to tech careers and skills for girls, right at the school level. Many companies are doing this, and we need more working professionals who spend time in schools, sharing and educating girls and boys on a career in tech and about the skills needed. Similarly, teachers who know how to teach coding and computer science in schools need to engage with girl students. Schools like Harvey Mudd, which create and craft curriculum to welcome women into tech and make the on-ramp into tech easier, also need to be encouraged for further initiatives.

To bring women into engineering, tech companies also need to make certain cultural changes in their recruiting, retention and development processes. Often, activities and culture are geared around men who have been the dominant group. From work hours to informal socialisation to how communication happens, companies should examine how this needs to change to make it easier for women to join and stay. Further, managers need to be trained to be inclusive and demonstrate as leaders how to include and support all the people in their teams. Lastly, CEOs and leaders of companies need to make this a business imperative and ensure that all levels of the organisation believe and support inclusion. I am proud to say that Western Digital does all this.